

Figure 16: B.K. Ramaier

In March, there was once again trouble in Colombo as the chief steward stopped supplying coal for outstanding dues. P.V. Ganapathia Pillai had to rush from Tuticorin to sort matters out,[12] and made further visits in April and May, possibly on the same business.[13] Meanwhile S. Somasundara Bharati and K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar proceeded to Tirunelveli from Tuticorin and consulted A. Sundara Sastri and B.K. Ramaier (Figure 16) about the Colombo Agent's account.[14]

In April 1909, Pandithurai Thevar who was 'already very largely interested' in SSNCo, continued to support the revival of the company going to the extent of considering mortgaging one of his zamindari villages for the purpose.[15] We do not know if the mortgage went ahead, but in June 1909 Subramania Bharati jubilantly reported that Pandithurai Thevar was advancing more money to the company, and therefore the steamers would start working in a week.[16] How much he invested in all is not known. His biography by Mu. Raghavaiyangar, a scholar patronized by him and who knew him for most of his adult life, is very sketchy. He blandly states that more than Rs 1 lakh was invested, resulting in 'distrust' between him and the government. Pandithurai Thevar surely deserved more credit.[17]